

» Luther himself was conservative in theology and in his respect for order, but many of those who followed him were far more radical.

Zwingli and Calvin

In Zurich, Switzerland, Ulrich Zwingli (1484–1531) converted the city along Lutheran lines: his 67 theses of 1523 were adopted by the city council as official doctrine. However, he disagreed with Luther about the nature of the Eucharist (the bread and wine received during communion) and began to lead the Swiss Church in a more radical, anti-hierarchical direction. His death in 1531 while defending Zurich against the Catholic cantons (provinces) of Switzerland slowed the momentum of the reformation in Switzerland. Calvin (see below), who was starting to create a new religious center in the city of Geneva, subsequently emerged as the key figure associated with protestant reform in Switzerland.

Calvin had converted to the new reformed faith in 1533 and settled in Geneva in 1536. There he developed a more austere form of Protestantism, based on his own reading of scriptures and his rigorous academic training, stressing predestination—God’s control of all human actions. Though Calvin himself did not develop any practical theory of resistance to “ungodly authority,” such as the Catholic Church or Catholic rulers, many of his successors were prepared to justify violent resistance through his teachings. Like Luther, he stressed both an individual’s direct relationship with God without a papal or priestly intermediary and the primacy of the Bible—now widely distributed in modern languages

RELIGIOUS REFORMER (1509–64)

JOHN CALVIN

Born in France, John Calvin prepared for a church career in Paris, but in 1533 experienced a “sudden conversion” to the reformed faith. He wrote the *Institutes of the Christian Religion* (1534), rejecting papal authority in favor of justification by faith alone. He settled in Geneva in 1536, where he sought to create a society in which the demands of

“godly behavior” were strictly enforced by a combination of church and civil authorities. The duty of the citizen was to interpret the Bible and create a godly society.

